Decoding ISO 9001 2026

Clause 9 Performance evaluation

Meaningful measures internal audit and management judgement



Use evidence to judge the system and make a proportionate management decision.

Expanded practitioner edition for IMS managers, engineers and leadership teams

First edition | November 2026 | £4.99

RPG Excellence | Management Systems and Business Assurance

Using this publication

Use evidence to judge the system and make a proportionate management decision.

This expanded practitioner edition explains every numbered subclause within Clause 9 of the supplied ISO 9001:2026 text. It develops the earlier RPG collected technical insights into a standalone working guide with operational examples, role applications, two reusable worksheets and two printable poster annexes.

Requirements and recommendations

The required outcomes are original paraphrases of the supplied standard. Its informative Annex A clarifies meaning without adding requirements. Practical methods, scenarios, sample sizes, worksheet fields, review periods and poster prompts in this book are RPG recommendations, unless a requirement is expressly identified. Use a licensed copy for the complete normative text. [1]

How to read it

Begin with the working language and coverage route. Read the relevant clause interpretation, then follow one real process with its owner. Use the cases to challenge your reasoning and the worksheets to record a decision. The annexes can support team discussion; they are not exhaustive audit checklists.

Technical basis

Supporting referrals were checked against official public publication records on 8 November 2026. Many APG papers and ISO/TS 9002:2016 address the earlier edition. Use them only where consistent with the 2026 requirement. ISO 9000 supplies the normative vocabulary referral. Other supporting publications do not automatically expand ISO 9001 requirements.

All organisations, events and figures in the cases are fictional teaching examples. They are not customer results, statistical benchmarks or promised savings. Photographs are illustrative. This guide does not establish certification or replace applicable technical, contractual or legal assessment.

Working language and practical translation

These are plain English working explanations, not formal quotations or replacements for ISO 9000 definitions. The application column shows the decision each term should help a reader make.

Term	Working explanation	Practical translation
Monitoring	Keeping the state of something under observation.	Define what condition matters and how it is known.
Measurement	Determining a value through a suitable method.	Define the population, calculation and timing.
Analysis	Examining information to understand patterns and relationships.	Consider exceptions and competing explanations.
Evaluation	Reaching a judgement against a purpose or criterion.	State the conclusion and its evidence limits.
Suitability	Whether the arrangement fits the organisation and its context.	Revisit it when business conditions change.
Adequacy	Whether the arrangement and resources are sufficient.	Examine capability as well as the existence of a plan.

Read the verbs carefully

A requirement calls for fulfilment. Guidance suggests a possible approach. Thinking about an issue differs from incorporating it into a decision. Suitability depends on the organisation’s context, while applicability concerns whether a requirement is relevant to the situation. The supplied Annex A.2 and the vocabulary referrals help resolve these distinctions. [1]

Do not turn a preferred template, score or software workflow into a requirement simply because it is familiar. Equally, do not use flexible wording to avoid an outcome the standard actually requires.

Clause coverage and reading route

The references below cover every numbered subclause within this book’s main clause. Where related subclauses share a page, their required outcomes are distinguished in the text. Parent headings organise the requirements and are included in this coverage.

Covered references	Interpretation section
9.1, 9.1.1	9.1.1 Decide what to measure and when to evaluate it
9.1.2	9.1.2 Understand customer satisfaction beyond the survey
9.1.3	9.1.3 Analysis that leads to an evaluation
9.2, 9.2.1, 9.2.2	9.2.1 and 9.2.2 An audit programme that follows the work
9.3, 9.3.1, 9.3.2	9.3.1 and 9.3.2 Review the system on a complete basis
9.3.3	9.3.3 Make the review result an actionable decision

The question to carry through the book

What conclusion does the evidence support and what remains uncertain?

Read across the system

Clause interpretation supports a working process. It does not require the organisation’s manuals, software modules or department structure to mirror the numbering of the standard. The links to other clauses in this book help preserve that systems perspective. [1, A.1, A.2]

9.1.1 Decide what to measure and when to evaluate it

Required outcome

Determine the subjects to monitor and measure, suitable methods that produce valid results, the timing of collection and the timing of analysis and evaluation. Evaluate QMS performance and effectiveness, and keep documented evidence of the results. [1, A.9.1]

Practical translation

Monitoring provides information about a condition or status. Measurement assigns a value using an appropriate method. Analysis examines the information; evaluation makes a judgement against a purpose or criterion. A dashboard is a presentation, not the judgement itself.

Application in the work

For delivery performance, define whether the measure uses the original customer commitment or a later agreed date. Both can answer useful questions, but they should not be presented as the same result. Identify the population, reporting period, exclusions, data source and calculation before comparing teams.

Evidence and judgement

A practical metric definition includes the intended decision, numerator, denominator, collection responsibilities and limitations. Examine missing records and changes in definitions. Choose methods suited to the available data and the consequence of the decision rather than copying a familiar chart.

Avoid this mistake

The clause does not prescribe a KPI count, universal target or specific statistical technique. A green indicator based on incomplete or inconsistent data cannot establish effectiveness.

Guidance referral

A.9.1 clarifies the measurement to decision relationship. ISO 10017:2021 provides earlier edition guidance on selecting statistical techniques, not detailed statistical instruction. [6]

9.1.2 Understand customer satisfaction beyond the survey

Required outcome

Monitor customer satisfaction and determine the methods used to obtain, monitor and review suitable information. The standard recognises several potential sources of customer information rather than prescribing a single measurement instrument. [1, A.9.1]

Practical translation

A lack of complaints can mean satisfaction, but can also reflect silence, a difficult complaints route or a customer who has stopped buying. Survey results depend on who responded, what was asked and which part of the service the response concerns.

Application in the work

Compare delivery discussions, complaints, repeat enquiries, relevant survey responses and service observations. A customer may be satisfied with a technical result and dissatisfied with the information or timeliness around it. Identify the aspect that the organisation can address before choosing an action.

Evidence and judgement

Record how the information was obtained, its period and population, and how the organisation reached its conclusion. For a small number of strategic customers, a structured discussion may be more useful than a large generic survey. Review the limitations of whichever method is chosen.

Avoid this mistake

No universal annual survey, net promoter score or satisfaction percentage is imposed by ISO 9001. Nor does repeat business alone prove satisfaction when alternatives are limited or the contract is fixed.

Guidance referral

ISO 10004:2018 is a dedicated guidance referral for monitoring and measuring external customer satisfaction. [5]

9.1.3 Analysis that leads to an evaluation

Required outcome

Analyse and evaluate relevant monitoring and measurement information to judge output conformity, customer satisfaction, QMS performance and effectiveness, implementation of planning, effectiveness of risk actions and opportunity actions, external provider performance and improvement needs. [1]

Practical translation

These subjects have different evaluation questions. A completed action establishes implementation; a supported change in the targeted condition informs effectiveness. An opportunity needs evidence of its beneficial result, not simply proof that the project launched.

Application in the work

A complaint count falls as the volume of delivered work falls. Examine the rate as well as the count and consider severity, reporting behaviour and the affected customer population. If work mix changes, an apparent improvement may reflect the mix rather than a better process.

Evidence and judgement

Use comparable definitions, appropriate denominators and an explicit observation period. Examine disagreement between indicators. Explain why the method supports the proposed conclusion and what information is missing. A bounded conclusion is more useful than a confident statement that the evidence cannot support.

Avoid this mistake

A before and after difference does not by itself establish causation. An average can conceal a material failure in a small but important group. Select more detailed analysis where the decision requires it.

Guidance referral

A.9.1 refers to quality tools and statistical guidance. ISO 10017 and ISO 10014 provide optional referrals for analysis and leadership interpretation. [6,7]

9.2.1 and 9.2.2 An audit programme that follows the work

Required outcome

Under 9.2.1, conduct internal audits at planned intervals to evaluate conformity to the organisation’s own QMS requirements and ISO 9001, and effective implementation and maintenance. Under 9.2.2, establish and operate programmes covering frequency, methods, responsibilities, planning and reporting, considering process importance, previous results and organisational changes. Define each audit’s objectives, criteria and scope, preserve objectivity and impartiality, report to relevant managers, take correction and corrective action without undue delay and retain programme and result evidence. [1]

Practical translation

An audit asks whether criteria are fulfilled in the work. A programme should allocate attention to what matters, including changes, poor results and consequential interfaces. Completing planned calendar entries is not sufficient if the programme repeatedly avoids the uncertain work.

Application in the work

Trace a changed requirement from acceptance through delivery and release. Combine document review with interviews, observation and examination of relevant records. Select a competent auditor arrangement that protects impartiality, including where a small organisation needs an alternative reviewer.

Evidence and judgement

A supported finding identifies the criterion, the observed evidence and the resulting gap. Explain sampling boundaries. Programme records should show the implemented activity and its results, while follow up should address the correction and cause where corrective action is required.

Avoid this mistake

ISO 9001 does not require every process to be audited once per calendar year or mandate a particular checklist. Sample size is a justified audit choice, not a universal number supplied by this book.

Guidance referral

ISO 19011:2026 provides auditing guidance. APG papers offer supplementary techniques with their stated limitations. [4,3]

9.3.1 and 9.3.2 Review the system on a complete basis

Required outcome

Under 9.3.1, top management reviews the QMS at planned intervals for continuing suitability, adequacy, effectiveness and strategic alignment. Under 9.3.2, include prior action status; changes in context and relevant party expectations; trends in nonconformity and corrective action, measurement, audit, satisfaction and feedback, objectives, process and output results, and external providers; improvement opportunities; resource adequacy; and effectiveness of risk and opportunity actions. [1]

Practical translation

Suitability asks whether the arrangement still fits the business. Adequacy asks whether what is provided is sufficient. Effectiveness asks whether the intended result is achieved. A review can reveal an effective local process that is no longer adequate for the organisation’s changed commitments.

Application in the work

A growth plan depends on specialist review capacity. Present the work profile, delayed decisions, competence development, provider options and customer effects alongside the proposed commitments. A green average utilisation measure should not conceal the specific bottleneck.

Evidence and judgement

A sequence of coordinated reviews can fulfil the purpose when the required inputs and overall evaluation are covered. Keep traceability between evidence, discussion and the management decision. The planned interval should be suitable for the organisation’s circumstances and changes.

Avoid this mistake

An annual meeting and a standard slide deck are not prescribed formats. A review that merely records every topic as noted may fail to show a meaningful judgement about the system.

Guidance referral

A.9.3 explains the decision purpose and organisational choice of intervals. ISO 10014 supports leadership use of quality information. [7]

9.3.3 Make the review result an actionable decision

Required outcome

The review results must include decisions about continual improvement opportunities and any required changes to the QMS and its resources. Keep documented evidence of the review results. [1]

Practical translation

A decision needs an intelligible connection to the evidence considered. Where a change or resource is required, the organisation needs a practical route from the authorised result to implementation and evaluation. An unchanged arrangement can be a justified decision, but it should not be confused with failure to consider the issue.

Application in the work

Management determines that a proposed delivery increase exceeds currently demonstrated technical review capability. The resulting decision might phase acceptance, provide competent cover and set a review after representative work. Link that decision to the controlled planning and change arrangements.

Evidence and judgement

An RPG decision record can identify the conclusion, authority, accountable owner, resource, timing, evaluation evidence and any remaining exposure. Review actions from earlier decisions to determine whether they achieved their purpose, rather than only whether tasks were marked complete.

Avoid this mistake

ISO 9001 does not prescribe a template or require an action simply to populate every review topic. However, records with no discernible decision about an identified need provide weak evidence of the required review result.

Guidance referral

A.9.3 clarifies management review. The requirements for planning and improvement in Clauses 6 and 10 remain connected to the review’s decisions.

Apply the clause across the team

These responsibilities are recommended applications for the reader groups. The organisation still determines its own roles, competence and authority.

Reader	Contribution	Useful output
IMS manager	Establish reliable definitions and connect assurance results.	An evidence account with limitations and unresolved questions.
Engineer	Assess whether technical data and sampling support the proposed conclusion.	A defensible interpretation and any further test needed.
Leadership team	Decide suitability, adequacy, effectiveness and resource implications.	A documented management judgement and follow through.

Use it in an integrated management system

An integrated review can use shared data and a coordinated audit programme. Keep the applicable criteria and important exceptions visible for each management system. A combined dashboard should not turn fundamentally different measures into a meaningless overall compliance score. Data quality, confidentiality and the competence to interpret technical results remain relevant.

Connections that should remain visible

Related clause	Connection to this decision
Clause 4	Changed context can alter what the organisation needs to evaluate.
Clauses 6 and 8	Planning and operational evidence provide subjects for analysis.
Clause 5	Top management must use the review to govern the system.
Clause 10	Conclusions and decisions inform improvement and corrective action.

Engineering case Complaints halve but the rate rises

Fictional scenario for practical discussion

Fictional Eldon Engineering receives 12 complaints against 1,000 delivered orders in one period and six against 300 in the next. These invented data show a count reduction of 50 per cent, while the observed rate rises from 1.2 per cent to 2.0 per cent.

The rate difference is 0.8 percentage points. Relative to the baseline rate, it is about a 66.7 per cent increase. Neither comparison alone establishes the reason. Review complaint definitions, lag, severity, work mix and the relationship between complaint dates and delivered orders.

The leadership team should not declare improvement on the count alone. The next decision can be a targeted analysis of the affected customer and process groups, alongside any immediate response to serious individual complaints. Report the uncertainty and proposed test.

A sophisticated chart cannot rescue an inappropriate population. A rate is more informative for some questions, but it still needs a sound definition and an understanding of the business context.

Use the case with your team

Identify the applicable requirement, distinguish the observed facts from assumptions and decide what evidence would support the next action. Explain who has the authority and competence to make that decision. Discuss what would contradict your initial conclusion.

Your decision and the evidence still needed

Service case Every audit is complete

Fictional scenario for practical discussion

Fictional Linton Services reports full completion of its audit calendar. Over several cycles, auditors have selected routine jobs and omitted a changed remote delivery arrangement because its records are harder to retrieve. A significant customer problem later exposes a weak review interface.

The programme must be evaluated against process importance, changes and previous results. Completion of selected audits does not establish the adequacy of programme coverage. Review the objectives, competence, methods, access arrangements and sampling rationale.

A revised programme gives suitable attention to the changed process and tests the evidence available to ordinary users. Findings identify applicable criteria and the observed gaps. Follow up examines the corrected control and relevant cause, with management receiving an account of what remains unresolved.

The management review should decide whether capability, system changes or assurance resources are needed. Recording that the audit plan was revised establishes a response; subsequent implemented audits and operating evidence support evaluation of its effectiveness.

Use the case with your team

Identify the applicable requirement, distinguish the observed facts from assumptions and decide what evidence would support the next action. Explain who has the authority and competence to make that decision. Discuss what would contradict your initial conclusion.

Your decision and the evidence still needed

Audit the decision and plan the response

The following prompts are practical aids. Define the audit criteria and scope using the applicable requirements and the organisation’s own arrangements. A prompt in this table is not a separate mandatory ISO requirement.

Subject	Question to test	Weak signal
Measurement	What does the definition include and exclude?	A chart compared across changed populations or rules.
Customer information	Whose experience is represented?	Silence or a small response group treated as universal satisfaction.
Internal audit	Why did the programme allocate attention here?	Calendar completion substituted for risk relevant coverage.
Management review	Which decision followed from the evidence?	Minutes record only presentation and acknowledgement.

A focused implementation discussion

1. Choose one reassuring indicator and reconstruct its calculation.

2. Test the population, definition, period and important exceptions.

3. Compare the conclusion with audit and customer information.

4. Record the management decision, further evidence needed and responsible owner.

Write a useful finding

Separate the criterion, what was observed and the resulting gap. Keep an improvement suggestion distinct from a nonconformity. Where immediate control is needed, use the appropriate operational authority rather than waiting for the audit report.

Record the next decision

Identify the responsible owner, the action or decision needed, the evidence of implementation and the test of effectiveness where relevant. Set timing proportionate to the issue. The organisation must determine what can proceed while uncertainty remains.

Measure to decision specification

Reusable RPG worksheet for internal application

Complete for one defined process or decision. Reference supporting records rather than copying a whole report. The worksheet is a suggested method; its fields are not additional requirements.

1. Decision and intended result

2. Population period source and exclusions

3. Calculation numerator denominator and comparison basis

4. Data quality uncertainty and important exceptions

5. Analysis evaluation and alternative explanations

6. Authorised conclusion and next evidence requirement

Completion check: can another competent reviewer understand the basis, authority and limitations of the decision?

Audit and management review follow through

Reusable RPG worksheet for internal application

Complete for one defined process or decision. Reference supporting records rather than copying a whole report. The worksheet is a suggested method; its fields are not additional requirements.

1. Criteria objective scope and selected process

2. Sampling method competence and impartiality

3. Evidence finding and limitation

4. Correction and corrective action where needed

5. Management conclusion resource or change decision

6. Owner timing and effectiveness review

Completion check: can another competent reviewer understand the basis, authority and limitations of the decision?

References and publication information

Official publication records and public guidance checked on 8 November 2026. The referral notes identify scope and appropriate use; they are not full reviews of the supporting standards. Obtain the full publication where it is needed.

[1] ISO 9001:2026 Quality management systems Requirements
Primary clause basis: the supplied standard text and its informative Annex A. Open official record

[2] ISO/TS 9002:2016 Guidelines for the application of ISO 9001:2015
Earlier edition implementation guidance; check compatibility with 2026. Open official record

[3] ISO 9001 Auditing Practices Group
Supplementary audit papers, many for the 2015 edition. Open official record

[4] ISO 19011:2026 Guidelines for auditing management systems
Guidance referral for programmes, audit conduct and auditor competence. Open official record

[5] ISO 10004:2018 Customer satisfaction monitoring and measurement
Guidance referral for external customer satisfaction information. Open official record

[6] ISO 10017:2021 Statistical techniques for ISO 9001:2015
Earlier edition technique selection guidance, not instruction in every technique. Open official record

[7] ISO 10014:2021 Financial and economic benefits from quality
Leadership guidance referral; published in support of earlier QMS editions. Open official record

[8] ISO 9000:2026 Quality management Fundamentals and vocabulary
Normative vocabulary referral identified by ISO 9001. Open official record

[9] ISO 9000 Glossary Guidance on selected words 2025
Supporting language clarification. Use formal definitions where applicable. Open official record

Rights and use

Copyright 2026 RPG Excellence. First expanded edition, November 2026. Standalone digital publication price £4.99. Purchasers may copy and adapt the two worksheets and print the poster annexes for internal use within their own organisation, retaining attribution. This permission excludes resale, public redistribution and inclusion in a commercial template library. Third party materials retain their own rights.

Independent commentary, not issued or endorsed by ISO, BSI or a certification body. This publication is not the standard and purchase does not confer certification. It expands the RPG collected technical insights series without reproducing the licensed normative text.

Published by RPG Excellence | info@rpgexcellence.com | www.rpgexcellence.com

From a number to a defensible conclusion

Practical prompts for applying the requirements. Read with the publication and the licensed standard.

01

Purpose

Which decision is the measure intended to support?

02

Definition

What population, period and calculation apply?

03

Quality

Are the records complete and the method valid?

04

Analysis

What do patterns and exceptions suggest?

05

Evaluation

What conclusion is supported and what is uncertain?

06

Decision

Who acts and what evidence will be reviewed next?

RPG recommended practice. These prompts do not add ISO requirements.

Copyright 2026 RPG Excellence. Internal printing permitted with attribution.

Make the assurance trail useful

Practical prompts for applying the requirements. Read with the publication and the licensed standard.

01

Audit programme

Allocate attention to importance, change and previous results.

02

Audit evidence

Connect the criterion, observation and actual gap.

03

Follow up

Distinguish correction from effective corrective action.

04

Management review

Evaluate fit, sufficiency and achieved results.

05

Decision

Address improvement, system changes and resource needs.

06

Common trap

Completion of the activity is not proof of effectiveness.

RPG recommended practice. These prompts do not add ISO requirements.

Copyright 2026 RPG Excellence. Internal printing permitted with attribution.